

Regular Meeting
Monday, September 23, 2019
Medford School Committee
Medford High School

Present: Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Ruggiero, Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke, Superintendent Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Associate Superintendent Diane Caldwell, and Assistant Superintendent Peter Cushing. Ms. DiBenedetto arrived at 7:02pm.

Roll Call and Salute the Flag - Meeting called to order at 7:00pm.

Approval of Minutes of September 9, 2019 - Motion to approve offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion passes.

Approval of Bills/Transfer of Funds and Approval of Payrolls - Motion to approve offered by Ms. Kreatz, seconded by Mr. Ruseau.

Roll call vote.

6 - Affirmative

1 - Absent - Ms. DiBenedetto

Motion to take papers 2, 3, and 10 out of order, motion passes.

Recognition of Joseph Farah for Contributions to the Event Horizon Telescope Project - Rocco Cieri - Mr. Farah was a 2017 graduate of Medford High School. He is the only undergraduate named in all six research papers connected with the black hole photography project. We recognize Joseph because he has received the Breakthrough prize. I want to congratulate him personally: he is a true Mustang. Mayor Burke read the report officially into the record. Mr. Cieri mentioned that Joseph attends UMass Boston and is a testament to the pipeline and the value of public education in Massachusetts. Mr. Farah - Thank you especially to the science department at Medford High, they deserve the credit for this as much as I do.

Recognition of Ron Morin, Retiring Executive Director of Friends of the Fells - Mayor Burke - The Medford School Committee recognizes Mr. Morin's leadership as the Executive Director of the Friends of the Fells Reservation. We are lucky to have access to the living laboratory and we thank Mr. Morin for his contribution to protecting this space. Mr. Morin - The City of Medford gave us great support and we could not have done it without Mayor Burke. When the Mayor got behind us, that was the tipping point in our fight with DCR.

Report on Climate Strike Communication - Dr. Peter Cushing - Mr. Cushing read quotes by Greta Thunberg on taking action on climate change. He discussed how the decision was made to not excuse absences for students who decided to attend the Climate Strike in Boston. Mr. Cushing discussed that there are reasons people may decide to attend strikes or protests for less noble causes. He suggested that this issue is bigger than an excused or unexcused absence.

Mr. Ruseau - What are the hate rallies you are referring to? Dr. Cushing - A few weeks ago there was a hate rally in Boston called the Straight Pride Parade. In Virginia someone drove a car into a crowd and killed someone. We believe that climate change is real and upon us, but excusing absences for a protest could be dangerous. Mr. Ruseau - If you call in sick on a Friday, does Medford Public Schools have a policy about what you can do on a Saturday and Sunday? Mayor Burke - For students or administration? Mr. Ruseau - My employer has no rules about what I can do on a weekend after taking a sick day. I believe it should be the policy of Medford Public Schools to not penalize students for taking a day off and then wanting to participate in activities on the weekend. Natural consequences are reasonable, but it is an unnatural consequence to take away a weekend activity. The band said that the students were going to ruin the band performance. Mr. Ruseau read a letter from a resident who was unable to attend the meeting. Mr. Ruseau - There was a middle ground here. Cambridge, Boston, Somerville, Arlington excused absences. I do not believe that the Superintendents in those districts do not take into account the students' safety. This is about whether the punitive measures were appropriate.

Ms. Van der Kloot - I was disappointed that students who would have liked to have gone to the march did not go because it would have adversely affected their ability to participate in activities. To me this is a School Committee policy question.

Motion that the School Committee meet to discuss the absentee policy with regard to outside events that students would like to participate in offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruseau.

Ms. Kreatz - In the future if we knew early enough could we plan a civic field trip to go into town with a teacher and attend with adult supervision? Dr. Cushing - Yes. I had about ten days and went to our nursing staff to see if we could make that happen and the turnaround time was too quick. We should engender student leadership on these issues. That is what Thunberg suggests. We should also be taking action and moving beyond conversation. Ms. Kreatz - Do we know how many students attended the strike? Dr. Cushing - Our attendance was off about a percentage point. Ms. Kreatz - Did teachers discuss climate change? Dr. Cushing - Yes, teachers were given resources and it was discussed in classes. It was seen as an opportunity for civil disobedience. Ms. Kreatz - Another idea is a walk-in, to do a strike within the school. Mr. Ruggiero - If a child had a chess tournament to attend that conflicted with school would that be

an excused absence? Dr. Cushing - I do not have the policy directly in front of me. That would be a non-school event and an unexcused absence. The faculty would likely see that as something enriching and that they could make up the work, as far as after school activities, that would be up to the principal. Mr. Ruggiero - I am slightly disappointed, the point of the walk-out is to draw attention to the fact that adults are not doing anything about it, and this policy supports that. We would not excuse students to attend a hate rally. We as a community, country, world, should recognize there is something more important than words on a page. I do not think that adults should be there necessarily. We should not penalize these students, we should excuse these absences, it is not fair.

Ms. Mustone - Can Member Van der Kloot amend her motion to send the issue to the policy subcommittee? Mr. Ruseau - This is civil disobedience, but when we give children the same consequences as us when they do not have the same rights as us it is unfair.

Anna Nowogrodzki, 20 Pleasant Street - My husband and I are here with our two year old. I am disappointed with the school's handling of this. I think that allowing students to miss school without punishment for the climate strike would not make you beholden to excuse them for other activities. You are allowed to excuse what you like and not other things. That argument suggests that all the other communities will excuse absences to attend hate rallies which is clearly not true. I think that students defying the U.S. government and the UN is enough of an obstacle, we do not need to be that obstacle as well.

Ms. Van der Kloot - I want to be clear that I do not agree with this policy. I am reminded of the styrofoam trays. We are not concerned enough. Our body is not feeling the pressure enough. We are not getting to it fast enough. We should make it happen. Mr. Ruggiero - I would like to excuse the 1% of students who did not attend school that day. Ms. Van der Kloot - It may be trickier than that. I am not sure that matters as much and I do not think we can go back and change that they could not have attended their extra-curricular activities. I am not against it but I am not sure how to do it. We can discuss it in the policy subcommittee and it can be retroactive. Mr. Ruggiero - There is a subset of students that we can excuse today. I do not think we are setting some awful precedent and everybody is going to go to Charlottesville to hit someone with their car.

On the motion by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruseau that the Rules Subcommittee meet to discuss the absentee policy with regard to outside events in which students would like to participate, Roll call vote.

7 Affirmative

0 Negative

Motion passes.

Ms. DiBenedetto - I ask that we not excuse the absences because the students will be saddened that they could have gone and participated.

Motion to accept the report and place on file offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Motion to revert to regular order of business offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Report of Committees, Buildings and Grounds Subcommittee - September 11, 2019 - Mea Mustone - We discussed speed bumps and flashing signs with the speed limit. When a flashing sign frees up it will go to the Medford High complex. The replacement curbs at the middle schools are nearly finished. We discussed the district's kitchen appliances and whether we can get rid of styrofoam trays. We are looking into updating our appliances and looking at grants to accomplish that. We saw a presentation on a Medford High School master plan. Ms. Kreatz suggested we make a subcommittee to discuss a master plan.

Motion to create a High School Master Plan Vision Subcommittee offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.

Ms. Kreatz - I would be happy to chair that subcommittee. Mayor Burke - In the past there was a comprehensive committee with various stakeholders.

Mr. Ruseau - I had a conference call with MSBA on Friday. We are rated at the highest level for the high school. We are at about a 50% reimbursement rate, so we would have to fund this work. There is no option for them to demolish the building and rebuild it without losing anything outside of K-12 schooling if we get a grant from MSBA. Additionally, it is untrue that the DPW has 6 employees: the Mayor has confirmed for me that there are 50 employees in the Department of Public Works, please amend the minutes to reflect this. Mr. Ruggiero - Can we make sure this does not go to subcommittee without all of us weighing in at some point? Mayor Burke - We would do a feasibility study, this is very early stages of this project. Ms. Mustone - This evolved from our subcommittee that it should be a committee of stakeholders from the community. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can we discuss who should be on the committee? Ms. Van der Kloot - While I appreciate Ms. Kreatz volunteering to be the chair and she may be, I believe the Mayor should appoint who is on the committee. We can ask the community who is interested. Mayor Burke - We can not do that tonight, we can reach out to the community comprehensively and establish a really broad committee. If there is anything in particular that someone wants to see they can

recommend it at the next meeting. Ms. Mustone - Who is interested in serving on the committee? Members Ruggiero, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, and Van der Kloot indicated interest.

On the motion to create a high school master plan vision subcommittee, motion passes.

Report of the Superintendent - Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I want to congratulate Antonia Collins, a 2019 graduate of Medford High School who received a \$1,000 scholarship for Spanish Language examinations. Only 12 students are chosen from 150,000 students each year. Our World Language students have a long history of achieving and it is a testament to the strength of that program.

Last Thursday, Mayor Burke and I visited with a student at the McGlynn Elementary School who found a power charge bit that resembled a .22 calibre bullet casing. We applaud the student for seeing something and saying something.

McGlynn Elementary School hosted curriculum night.

Our new Greater Boston League has expanded into the middle schools and it has been successful so far.

Fabian Ramirez gave a presentation on bullying to students in grade 5, 6, 7, and 8 at the McGlynn Schools thanks to the CCSR. He spoke about the importance of treating people the way you want to be treated. We thank the CCSR and the Cummings Foundation.

Our band competed this weekend and won second place.

Medford Kiwanis did their Jail Day fundraiser. Cache hosted the annual Mystic River Celebration. The annual motorcycle ride to honor Krystle Campbell and raise funds for the scholarship was this weekend.

Global Climate Change Week is September 20 through 27 and our teachers are addressing topics throughout this week.

Ms. Van der Kloot - At the Tufts Community Day I saw Diane Caldwell and Lisa Evangelista sitting in the sun giving out lovely bookmarks and I thank them.

Recommendation to Approve \$1,500 Grant from PFLAG to CCSR to support our LGBTQ+ population. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.
Roll call vote.

7 Affirmative
0 Negative
Motion passes.

Recommendation to Approve Liquor Permit for Taste of Italy - Motion to approve offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot.

Roll call vote.
7 Affirmative
0 Negative
Motion passes.

Report on Middle School Mathematics Program Overview & Implementation Update - Faiza Khan - Teachers are embracing the new program with some struggles but I am hopeful that with the professional development we have invested in, we can take on this challenge. There is also an accelerated math program. If a student is placed in or chooses to take accelerated math, they do the Big Ideas program, which we have chosen to stay with for those students. The purpose of the accelerated program is because it teaches two years of math in one year. Students can opt out or test into the program after the first year as well. I am confident that once students take the accelerated path they achieve the goal of taking AP or Honors calculus by the end of 12th grade. If students do not take the accelerated program they can still take AP or Honors calculus in high school. Mr. Ruggiero - Are the answers to the online programs recorded for you to review? Ms. Khan - No. The textbook is available online. It is not an online class. Mr. Ruggiero - How is our compliance percentage so far? Ms. Khan - There are concerns that teachers have and I have asked them to keep the data and also how much copy paper are they using. We are keeping track of how many times a student has lost a paper and come back to get it and how many reams of paper we are going through. Hopefully by the end of this year we will be able to have a concrete sense of things. Mr. Ruggiero - How is it going so far? Ms. Khan - It is going well. Teachers have to look at the synthesis and work backwards. It is a learning game this year and teachers are working very hard. Mr. Ruggiero - Can you help me understand the pedagogy? Ms. Khan described the program. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can you describe the struggles? Ms. Khan - Some supplies have been backordered. The new textbooks need to be numbered. Shipping them out can take time. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can we get an update on when all the materials will be delivered to all the teachers? Are we supporting all our students with high needs? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - We have co-teaching and EL support in the classes at the McGlynn. Ms. DiBenedetto - Are the co-teachers supplied with all materials? Ms. Khan - They can access everything online until their books come. The student and teacher editions and help for the families. Ms. DiBenedetto - Do the teachers have the consumables they need? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - This was brought to my attention and I saw that the supplies are readily available. While the curriculum is new and being introduced, it is a rigorous curriculum that requires students to think mathematically.

Adjustments can be made. There was not anything on the list that would prevent a skilled teacher from being able to execute the lesson. They may need to use some creativity until the other materials are available. There was backlog at the loading dock. Can you give a tentative time frame for when everyone will have a hard copy in hand? Ms. Khan - All general and special education teachers should have teacher's edition books and all classrooms should have classroom editions. I am speaking with EL teachers and 504/IEP requirements. We are backlogged on the EL teacher's editions. They are able to pull it up online. Ms. DiBenedetto - Are we asking teachers to supply consumables? Do we have all the non-consumables? I would like an update at our next meeting with everything they have and what they are missing.

Motion to see an updated version of this report with an update on backlogged supplies offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Mr. Ruseau - What percentage of 7th graders who take accelerated math end up taking the accelerated track in 8th grade? Ms. Khan - Most of them move forward. Mr. Ruseau - Not a big drop off. Ms. Khan - No. Mr. Ruseau - Do you know what elementary schools the students who take accelerated math went to? Ms. Khan - I have not done that data analysis, but I can get it. I do not want to position the elementary schools against each other. Mr. Ruseau - I have concerns about accelerated math. They do not study math thoroughly. Do they stick with math? Ms. Khan - I have wondered deeply about this. I can look into it. I know there are some students who do not want to stay in the accelerated track in high school. Mr. Ruseau - My main concern is the well-documented drop off for girls in math. Are all the girls taking accelerated math in middle school and in high school none of them are taking it? I know this is not universal. I want to make sure that if there is anything we are doing that feeds into that we are aware of it. Ms. Khan - This is a nationwide discussion we should ponder.

Ms. Kreatz - Can we attend a class? Ms. Khan - I think that would be great. Mr. Ruggiero - Do we know how many students are taking books to use at home that do not have access to computers at home? Ms. Khan - Not yet. I have instructed teachers to let us know if they need extra sets to make sure students are learning.

Motion to accept report and place on file offered by Mr. Ruggiero, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Report on Middle School Greater Boston League - Robert Maloney - Thank you to everyone who supported this, it is going very well. Mr. Tucci and Mr. Downs have been incredible assets to the program. Mayor Burke - Getting the GBL off the ground was not an easy task and I thank you for your hard work. Motion to accept the report and place on file offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Report on Dyslexia Screening Tools - Diane Caldwell - Ms. Caldwell reviewed the report. Mr. Ruggiero - Do any of these screenings address dysgraphia or dyscalculia? Ms. Caldwell - Suzannah Campbell can probably answer that for you. Mr. Ruggiero - Teachers attend PD and share what they learned with other teachers? Ms. Caldwell - Yes, the elementary teachers. Mr. Ruggiero - It would be great if we could have all the teachers attend. Ms. Caldwell - Yes. We are offering a series of workshops in Medford provided by two of our middle school teachers. There will be a workshop that a group of 5 or 6 will attend at Harvard. There is a webinar that we will be attending this week. Mr. Ruseau - Thank you, this was an excellent report. Thank you for backfilling for holes in particular screeners. How do we handle students who do not speak English as their primary language? Ms. Caldwell - We will assess EL students to find a baseline. Ms. Van der Kloot - Are we doing K-2 students in all schools? Ms. Caldwell - Yes. Ms. Van der Kloot - One on one? Ms. Caldwell - No, it is online, but we are working with our kindergarten students and taking more time because they are little. The first and second graders do it online. Ms. Van der Kloot - It would be great for School Committee members to see what they are doing. Ms. Caldwell - I agree. Ms. DiBenedetto - When we identify students what will we do? What are our next steps as a district? Will we open up the dyslexia committee to parents? Ms. Caldwell - We have a screening committee made up of me and administrators for the time being. We are hoping to put together a committee but we are just getting up and running. At the end of this school year the Department of Education should be putting out their requirements. Ms. DiBenedetto - We need a plan for the next phase. Ms. Caldwell - We do not diagnose children, they may have a tendency toward dyslexia, they would need further testing. Ms. DiBenedetto - What is the plan for supports? This may be a question for the curriculum subcommittee. When are the district's MCAS scores released? We will have a subcommittee meeting in mid- to late-October on this. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I thank Diane Caldwell, Dr. Chiesa, Katie Ciampoli, and Suzannah Campbell for their work on this. We are ahead of DESE on this work.

Motion to accept this report and place on file offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Report on English Learner Department Updates - Paul Teixeira - We had a successful summer for EL programs. Students learned about Massachusetts history, geography, civics, and took a trip to the State House. Students researched famous bridges and structures from around the world, including an in-house field trip where students made bridges and tested weight loads. The students played games, went on field trips, and created cars they crashed with an egg to see if they could keep their eggs safe. Students wrote code to program robot cars. Mayor Burke - What is the proportion of male to female participation? Mr. Teixeira - I think six males and three females. I can look up the data. Enrollment data: we have a fluid population. We are registering new students every day. I would like to acknowledge Jessie Reinhold, she is very welcoming and

exemplary at her job. She is detail oriented and makes placement decisions with 100% accuracy. We have a partnership with Lesley University, the Elementary Education Urban Initiative (EEUI). They do a year-long internship with our schools. In one case we hired one of the interns to fill a retirement. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can we guarantee the summer programs will continue? Mr. Teixeira - The hardest part is finding teachers. This year we broke it up with multiple teachers and it was successful.

Motion to accept this report and place on file offered by Ms. DiBenedetto, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Motion to adjourn offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Meeting adjourned at 9:16pm.